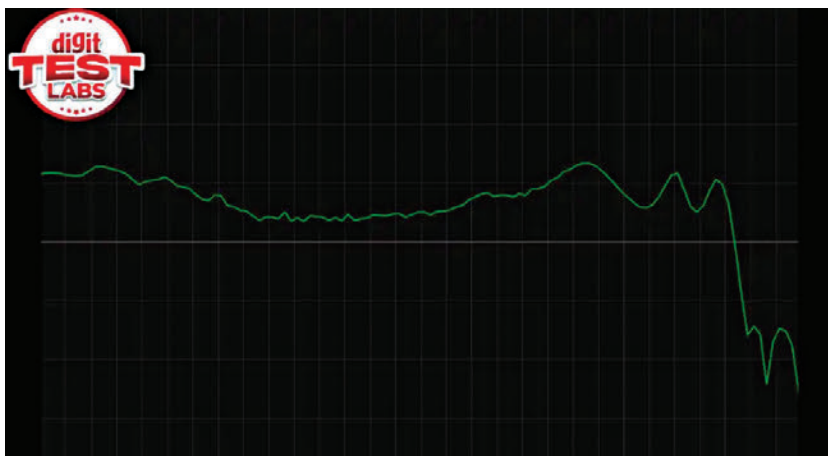




In comparison, the Realme Buds Air 8 is more expressive and impactful with more open soundstage and clearer instruments in a track like Sultans of the Swing by Dire Straits, and tighter and more controlled bass output in Main Aur Tu from Dhurandhar 2. Vocals of Arijit Singh in Phir Se, also from Dhurandhar 2, sound closer, more textured and a bit processed. In November by Max Richter, the Realme renders high-frequency details with better clarity and sharpness, giving the track a more atmospheric feel.

The OnePlus delivers these notes too, but they do not feel as defined or as close. It feels softer and more balanced.

There is support for LHDC 5.0 codec-based high-resolution sound, provided you have a compatible phone. We tried it on the OnePlus 15R, which supports this. In practice, the difference is slightly noticeable, even with high-quality local files like FLAC. It doesn't make a night-and-day difference if you stream via platforms like Spotify.

There is also EQ support, which lets you tweak the sound profile. You can choose between the given presets or create your own custom EQ. There

wasn't a major difference between the Balanced and Serenade profiles to my ears. The Bass presets work.

The Nord Buds 4 Pro includes spatial audio support, too, which is called OnePlus 3D Audio. It creates a wider soundstage that feels engaging to use.

BATTERY LIFE AND CHARGING

The company claims up to 13 hours on the OnePlus Nord Buds 4 Pro (with AAC and ANC off at 80% volume). One of the earbuds died around the 13-hour mark, and the other lasted an hour more.

While there is inconsistency between them, I will still take it. Moreover, with the case, you can expect to get a total of around 54 hours of runtime.

With ANC on, expect lower numbers, but enough to last a day of mixed use.

Charging time is around 60 minutes for the earbuds and 90 minutes for the full case. There is fast charging support, and the claim is up to 13 hours of playback with just 10-minutes of refuel.

VERDICT

The OnePlus Nord Buds 4 Pro is a value-heavy pair of earbuds that offers a bit of everything. It doesn't particularly stand

out, especially with the Realme Buds Air 8 also competing in the same space. But it is trying to be good at everything that matters, and mostly succeeds. That makes the Nord Buds 4 Pro an easy recommendation for anyone looking for a well-balanced TWS under Rs 5,000.

The Nord Buds 4 Pro gets the basics right. The sound is engaging without being messy, call quality is dependable, design is simple and comfortable, the Hey Melody app interface is user-friendly, and battery life is more than sufficient for daily use.

The ANC is very strong, but doesn't feel as aggressive as the Realme pair. That works in the Nord Buds' favour as it feels less fatiguing, especially for long listening. The same applies to the sound signature. Realme Buds Air 8 may be more dramatic and exciting, but OnePlus Nord Buds 4 Pro is easier to listen to for longer periods, which makes it the safer pick for most users.

Other features like Transparency mode, LHDC support, OnePlus 3D Audio, adaptive features, in-ear detection, and dual-device connectivity offer good utility and make the overall package feel more complete.

You shall consider the OnePlus Nord Buds 4 Pro if you want a fuss-free, feature-rich pair of earbuds that work across music, calls and everyday use. You can skip it if you are chasing the most aggressive value for money or a more exciting sound signature.

—G. S. Vasan

SPECIFICATIONS

Audio Drivers: 12 mm dynamic driver | Frequency Response: 20Hz - 40kHz | Mic sensitivity: -38dB | Mics: 6 microphones (3 per bud) | Rated Power: 5mW | Battery (Earbuds): 62 mAh | Battery (Case): 520 mAh | Charging: Wired type-C | Connectivity: Bluetooth 6.0 | IP rating: IP55

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